

EVENT: MPACT Transit + Community Conference (formerly known as RailVolution)

DATES: October 22-23, 2023

LOCATION: Philadelphia, Pennsylvania

ATTENDEE: Linda Marie Nunes, Legislative Aide to Councilmember Radiant Cordero

INTRODUCTION:

The MPACT Transit + Community Conference, formerly known as RailVolution, focuses on the intersection of transit, mobility, land use, and development investments to create inclusive and thriving communities.

MPACT gathers professionals and leaders of all backgrounds and experiences to help shape the vision for transit-oriented communities with discussions of ideas for new mobility or development projects, exchanges of best practices, and sharing of challenges and innovative solutions to be taken back to their respective regions and contribute to improving and building better communities.

This year, the City & County of Honolulu Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) stakeholders were invited to participate in a session on its Equitable TOD (ETOD) journey in Kalihi. The “MPACT LAB Presents—Activating ETOD in HI and PA: A LAB Exercise” session will include presentations from both Honolulu, HI, and Pottstown, PA, that share the challenges of how to implement ETOD from the ground up.

Furthermore, participating in this conference helps our Honolulu government representatives and stakeholders gain valuable insights and learn from other communities who have more experience with ETOD, and work to ignite place-based coalitions that work on transit, land use, and community development to assist with planning for Honolulu's next steps.

Tuesday, October 22, 2024

Plenary Session: 8:30 a.m. to 10:00 a.m.

Missing Middle Neighborhoods: Keys from Philadelphia

Emcee – Diana Mendes, Corporate President, Infrastructure and Mobility Equity, HNTB / President, Mpact Board of Directors, Washington, DC

Video Address – Congressman Earl Blumenauer, 3rd District, Oregon / Mpact Board of Directors

Welcome – Christopher Coes, Acting Under Secretary of Transportation for Policy, Office of the Secretary, US Department of Transportation, Washington, DC

Moderator: Kevin Moran, Executive Director, Urban Land Institute (ULI), Philadelphia, PA

Nikil Saval, State Senator, District 1, Pennsylvania State Senate, Philadelphia, PA

Jamie Gauthier, Councilmember, District 3, Philadelphia City Council, Philadelphia, PA

James Leonard, Commissioner, Department of Records, City of Philadelphia, Philadelphia, PA

Overview:

The morning plenary session highlighted policymakers in Philadelphia and how they are working to build wealth, prevent displacement, and reduce vacancy in “missing middle” neighborhoods. This session shed light on how livable communities can be built through investment in transportation.

Congressman Earl Blumenauer was not able to attend in person but shared a video address. In his remarks, he hoped that this conference will allow us to engage and learn from each other, and despite the challenges we face, know that we are showing and connecting people through transit-oriented development (TOD).

The speakers highlighted that transit is now able to connect communities that were once separated, and their key strategies to its success are:

1. Zoning Reform: Land use policies are crucial to supporting the goals for TOD.
2. Developing better coordination between land use and transportation planning.

Senator Nikil Saval shared about the Whole-Home Repair Program, which allots funding to counties for homeowners and landowners to make essential repairs to their homes. This would include repairs to the roof, asbestos, energy efficiency, or emergencies, amongst others. This program helps to preserve the homes that would have otherwise been lost. It gives people the opportunity to make the necessary renovations to meet requirements, such as to provide Section 8 housing. What helped make this program a success was that they hired someone who was dedicated to focus on the program.

Commissioner James Leonard shared the difficulties their Department of Records has with folks with tangled titles, which are when the legal owners are deceased and their family or heirs have not taken the steps to go through probate or divide the home. So the current residents, if repairs are needed, have a difficult time. This is not just for the current generation but also prior generations and can span over years that family or heirs live in the home but not on the property deed. Not being listed on the deed, the occupants cannot do anything to the property, such as take out loans on the property, or anything associated with the property, such as utilities or taxes. This puts occupants in a vulnerable state, and most of the time this is not an issue for the occupants until they are in a crisis, and since they are not the legal owners, issues arise and they won't qualify. This can contribute to the loss of middle homes. He suggested watching the documentary “Gaining Ground.” Additionally, there is an Act going through Congress, the Uniform Partition of Heirs Property Act (UPHPA), which would help heirs keep their home so that developers will not be able to take advantage of their vulnerable situation.

Councilmember Jamie Gauthier talked about the legislative measures she passed to include Mixed Income Neighborhood Districts, the People's Preservation Package, Defying Displacement, the Public Land for Public Benefit Bill, and the Neighborhood Preservation Initiative (NPI), amongst others. She also shared about their Turn the Key program that allows for City property to be accessible to developers to build affordable housing, and they were able to successfully create 1,000 affordable housing units.

As a collective, their approach to coalition building is to meet and talk with constituents and stakeholders because it is important to have all the voices of all stakeholders, even if they do not agree. If there is a conflict, meet folks where they are and work together towards the end goal. Look at what can be done to support both sides in order to reach the end goals. When discussing what can be implemented elsewhere, the majority of what was shared is replicable and currently being replicated in certain places, such as the Whole-Home Repair program. It was noted that there is a national bill that seeks to create a national whole-home repair pilot. In order to help the missing middle neighborhoods, policies need to be in place to preserve, protect, and generate affordable housing for everyone, and seeing what Philadelphia has done from their history to culture can prove that development can be equitable.

Additionally, to not only look at developing new housing but also understanding the communities and people at risk, such as those with tangled titles, and helping them to preserve their home.

Furthermore, I was able to network, and I met two community planners, April and Alex, who work for the U.S. Department of Transportation (USDOT), Office of Planning and Environment, and offered their contact should Honolulu need any assistance with planning for TOD.



Session: 10:30 a.m. – 12:00 p.m.

Land Use for Climate Action: Strategy, Funding, Impacts

Moderator: Liya Rechtman, Policy Advisor, U.S. Department of Transportation, Washington, DC

Ann Shikany, Deputy Assistant Secretary – Transportation Policy, U.S. Department of Transportation, Washington, DC

Kera Package, Deputy Assistant Secretary, Office of Community Planning and Development, US Department of Housing and Urban Development, Washington, DC

Christopher Hoehne, PhD Mobility Systems Research Scientist, National Renewable Energy Laboratory, Golden, CO

Overview:

As Liya Rechtman pulled up the chart listing the emissions trends and goals, while there are other factors that contribute to greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions such as agriculture, buildings, industry, and electric power, transportation was the largest source of U.S. GHG emissions with 33%. Of that 33%, 49% was from light duty vehicles (cars), followed by 21% from medium and heavy vehicles (trucks and buses), amongst others, with the lowest at 2% from rail. The goal is

to get 50–52% below 2005 levels by 2023 and reach net zero by 2050. This session discussed the strategies to help reach this goal.

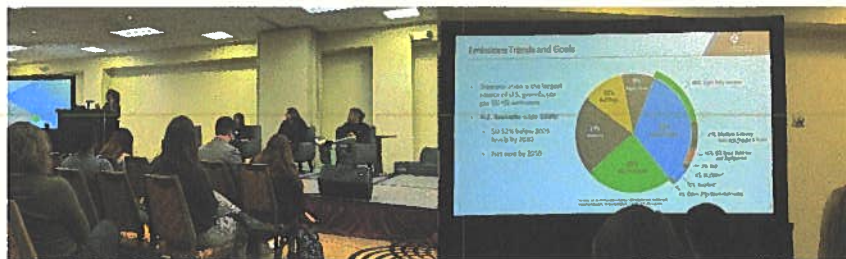
A joint strategy that was brought up was *The U.S. National Blueprint on Transportation Decarbonization*, which was developed by the USDOT, U.S. Department of Energy (DOE), U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD), and Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) to reach net zero transportation GHG by 2050. This was released in January 2023. I found it important to know that we must address the increase in demand for vehicle travel in order to decarbonize the transportation sector. The transportation decarbonization strategies include improving community design and land use planning, increasing options to travel more efficiently, and transitioning to zero emission vehicles and fuels.

Additionally, we got to hear from USDOT Deputy Assistance Secretary Ann Shikany, who spoke about the Blueprint as well as the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law. These take into account housing and climate impacts. She listed various programs, including the TOD grant to incorporate affordable housing. Also, it was noted that the USDOT Policy Office will be providing alternatives that can be used and guidance on how these alternatives can be incorporated in the planning process.

HUD Deputy Assistance Secretary Kara Package touched upon how various analyses still need to be done and we need to be forward-thinking. She noted that where there is a lack of supply in housing, there will be an increase in the market. Unfortunately, people spend half of their paycheck on housing and transportation. HUD is working with communities through various grant programs, such as the Section 108 Loan Guarantee Program (https://www.hud.gov/program_offices/comm_planning/section108).

National Renewable Energy Laboratory (NREL) Mobility Systems Research Scientist Dr. Christopher Hoehne, who spoke on how their research is motivated by the Blueprint and looks at accessibility and where there are gaps in the transportation system. The National Labs help States do is to provide them with information for them to get “the best bang for their buck.”

As a group, they shared how there are many valuable resources that are available to us on their websites. Both agencies are working collectively through interagency partnerships to help build bridges and meet people where they are to connect them with available resources. They emphasized that partnerships and working with stakeholders are crucial to being able to work across silos. Furthermore, working with the National Labs is also important as it allows them to understand the strategies that need to be taken in order to achieve their goal, such as to cut GHG emissions.



Session: 2:00 p.m. – 3:30 p.m.

MPACT LAB Presents – Activating ETOD in HI and PA: A LAB Exercise

Jennifer Sabas, Executive Director, Move Oahu Forward, Honolulu, HI

Howard Brown, Senior Program Officer, Pottstown Area Health & Wellness Foundation, Pottstown, PA

Sarah Rudolf, Associate Director, Mpact (formerly Rail~Volution), Minneapolis, MN

Overview:

On behalf of Councilmember Radiant Cordero, I joined the Hawaii delegation for this conference to represent Honolulu, especially TOD in Kalihi, at the “Activating ETOD in HI and PA” session. The Hawaii delegation for this conference included Jennifer Sabas, Executive Director of Move Hawaii Forward; Dawn Hirai from Move Oahu Forward; Hilarie Alomar from Kamehameha Schools; Tim Streitz from City’s Department of Planning and Permitting; Jon Nouchi, Deputy Director for the City’s Department of Transportation Services; Kevin Auger, Deputy Director for the Mayor’s Office of Housing; Kathleen Chu, Vice President at Bowers + Kubota; and Kiana Otsuka from the Oahu Metropolitan Planning Organization.

There were more than 80 people who participated in this working session, where we were able to share our experience and plans for Kalihi TOD, as well as learn from other communities about their best practices and lessons learned. Following the presentations from Hawai‘i (HI) and Pennsylvania (PA), we broke into small groups, with each group diving into a specific question:

1. How can we ensure an adequate supply of affordable housing and compassionately engage with unhoused individuals before, during, or after TOD?
2. How do we show people what the new TOD infrastructure looks/feels like?
3. How can we help people “see” themselves in TOD/upcoming changes to come?

Hilarie and I helped to facilitate the HI table for the question on “How can we help people “see” themselves in TOD/upcoming changes to come? Certain topics were shared, such as meeting people where they are by bringing awareness to TOD at community events or meetings. Understanding that placemaking or placekeeping is important to help people see how they fit in TOD. As gentrification is a common concern for TOD, it is crucial to get the people who are already there in the community involved from the beginning so that they are a part of the discussion of what is envisioned for their community.

Following the small group discussion, we joined the PA group with the same question, and I learned that Pottstown has events for their community known as “Place Streets,” where they engage their community in the vision of TOD. Another member shared the idea of the concept of “Xbox” and showcasing TOD using “Cityscapes.” Creative ideas were shared on how we possibly could get people in the community to see themselves in TOD and any upcoming changes that may come.

As each group shared their responses to the questions, community engagement is very important for the success of TOD and ensuring that the needs of the community are met. A developer from Chicago shared with everyone that they don’t use the term affordable housing but instead the term workforce housing. He shared that developers do not want to see people displaced from

what they do, and in Chicago they have Real Property Tax incentives to enable rent to remain affordable for seniors on fixed income to prevent displacement of existing residents.

Finally, to show people what the new TOD infrastructure would like, ideas such as having a pilot pop-up park or demonstration projects. It is important to know the needs of the community and get them involved to help revision the potential future for the community, Kalihi.



Session: 4:00 p.m. – 5:00 p.m.

Growing the Next Generation of Transit Riders

Rachel DeCordoba, Program Manager, King County Metro Transit, Seattle, WA

Theresa Thompson-Nix, Program Manager, Move Minnesota, Saint Paul, MN

Asher Polsky, Student, Lower Merion School District, Philadelphia, PA

Facilitator: Eric Tunell, Senior Urban Planner, Arcadis, Los Angeles, CA

Overview:

It was inspiring to see how the King County Metro's Youth Mobility Program and the Move Minnesota organization help to educate and promote transit for the youth. They provide education to youth to understand what a bus is and what to expect when riding it. From in a classroom setting to going out and actually riding the bus, they are helping young people become capable transit users and advocates for transit.

The first part to begin a program like this is education. We must know who the target audience is and understand that per age group the conversation and activities will defer. It is important to be transparent and tell it how it is, use digital tools, and emphasize that safety is the priority. For King County Metro, they have different modules for students from kindergarten to fifth grade and from sixth grade to twelfth grade. These modules target the age groups to help them get to know the metro, ride the metro safe and right, and make sustainability and community connections. Rachael shared that having activity sheets can help introduce students to transit, in addition to bringing a transit professional into the classroom to speak and meet the students.

For Move Minnesota, Theresa Thompson shared their timeline from 2021 to present. They encountered various challenges, such as drive shortages as well as students not feeling safe. However, through their efforts to work with the school district level, engage in student focus groups, implement transit education in middle schools and have those students start taking the bus, update their website with more transit resources and step-by-step process, as well as have student volunteers to help their peers ride the bus, and increase school engagement by having transit as a life skill for students.

Additionally, hearing from Asher Polsky, who is a John Hopkin's student and avid transit rider, was motivating. He made us laugh when he shared that public transit gave him in-house entertainment as he shared a video of a rat trying to pull a bread into drainage, but the bread was too large. However, on a serious note, he shared that transit allowed him to gain access to places he otherwise would not have gone, connect with his friends, and not have to worry about driving in traffic or finding parking. He did share that there needs to be more education about transit. Since he has been riding the bus and trains, he was able to help his friends navigate the system. More people would ride transit if they were comfortable knowing how to ride it. Lastly, he shared with us a map he created using the U.S. S0802 Census data:

<https://pr0diga1.github.io/map/>.

When we were asked to raise our hand about how we were introduced to riding transit, the majority were introduced by a family member, including myself. Some were actually introduced in school, and it was awesome to hear that in some schools there is a Transit Club. Providing education and access is the key to growing the next generation of transit riders.



Networking: 8:00 p.m. – 10:00 p.m.

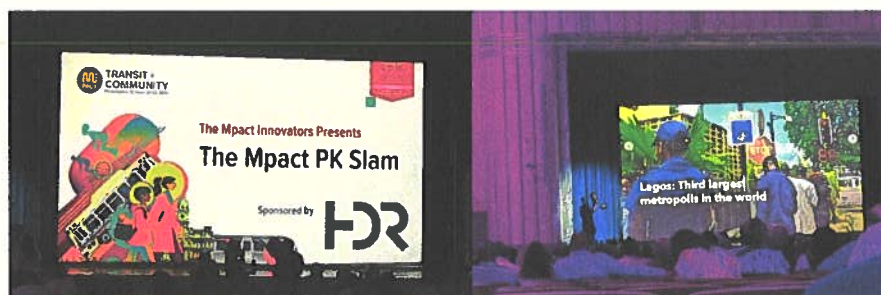
MPACT Innovators Presents – The Mpact PK Slam

Location: Bok, 1901 South 9th St, Philadelphia, PA

Overview:

With a group of conference attendees, we rode the SEPTA Regional Rail and walked to the Bok. I was impressed by multiple options to pay to ride the rail, which included tap and go using Apple or Google Pay. The Bok building was formally a school that was turned into a work space with restaurants, a coffee shop, and more. The Bok marks its 9th year and is home for 600 employees.

At the PK Slam, we were able to hear from different speakers sharing their rendition of transit in a stand-up PechaKucha™ style presentation. Ultimately, with the message that everywhere in the world there is a need for transit, but you need people for transit. The PK Slam was a great event to network with other attendees.



Wednesday, October 23, 2024

Session: 8:30 a.m. – 10:00 a.m.

Creative Placekeeping: How Art Supercharges Community Engagement

Moderator: Katherine Dirga, Director of Art in Transit, Metropolitan Atlanta Rapid Transit Authority (MARTA), Atlanta, GA

Ashley Bella, Chief Executive Officer, ArtzyBella, absATL, Atlanta, GA

Jane Golden, Executive Director, Mural Arts Philadelphia, Philadelphia, PA

Dorian McDuffie, Public Art Program Manager, Atlanta City Design Studio, Atlanta, GA

Overview:

Of all the sessions available at the conference, this was the only session about art. They hope that next year there will be more sessions dedicated to art in public spaces, as art is a form of creative placekeeping, which is not just a tool for beautification but also provides an opportunity to create effective public engagement and create informed, empowered, and connected communities.

It was shared that communities come together because of art, be it painting it together while having civic discussion or talking about it in passing. Painting of murals has been increasing around Council District 7, especially at schools. There is also artwork on the pillars of Honolulu's Skyline, which showcases specific detail pertaining to the area. These are creative art pieces that are tied to the community it is located in to show those passing what the community is about.

In this session, Ashley spoke on how her creative art pieces brought people together who otherwise would not have met. It connected the community and developers to understand the vision for the future of their community. It was refreshing to hear how creative placekeeping helps the people living there feel connected to the changes occurring in their community because they are welcomed to be a part of the discussion. Ashley shared that she tries to leave the people better than how she finds them, and as an artist, that is their mindset—how their art can provide community and individual support and healing.

Dorian McDuffie and Jane Golden shared how their respective communities support art in the community. Dorian shared about their pop-up urban design studio, Atlantic City Studio, which is under their City's Department of Planning's Office of Design. Their City saw its value and developed an office specifically for the purpose of connecting community and art. Some of their projects included painting crosswalks and bus shelters, but they also turned bus shelters into art itself.

Jane Golden emphasized that art is a way to bring people into a civic area where discussions can begin. She shared about the Mural Arts Philadelphia, which offers programs that use art as a way to provide individual and community healing. Their Porch Light program is joint with Philadelphia's Department of Behavioral Health and Intellectual disAbility Services, which provides opportunities for people to contribute to creating meaningful art. Additionally, she shared about their Color Me Back program, which is a same-day work and pay program that

combines art and access to social services. Their concept is to meet people where they are and, through art, be an avenue to help achieve wellness and healing for the community.

Since murals are seen as civic assets, restoration is a need, which will require funding. For them, they do have an office designed to seek grants for restoration or have a restoration program that keeps tabs on the artwork to know what its current condition is and which art needs restoration. Fortunately, because they have had heavy community involvement, there has not been any defacing of the art. With community involvement, they take ownership of it, and it is a way to tell the community that, “You are here, you count, and you matter!” However, to have a successful department or agency, it does require someone who is passionate about the work and is willing to put in the effort to see it thrive.



Session: 10:30 a.m. – 11:30 a.m.

Creative Fare Policies

Moderator: Gabrielle Pristera, Senior Sales Development Specialist, Southeastern Pennsylvania Transportation Authority (SEPTA), Philadelphia, PA

Ryan Reeves, Principal Planner, San Francisco Bay Area Rapid Transit District (BART), San Francisco, CA

Lilly Shoup, AICP, Managing Director, Transportation Policy and Partnerships, Rebel, Los Angeles, CA

Ruth Miller, MCP, Director of Product Partnerships, jawnt, Boston, MA

Terence Lee, Associate Program Coordinator, Funding Policy and Programs, Metropolitan Transportation Commission (MTC), San Francisco, CA

Nicola Mammes, Program Director, Zero Fare, City of Philadelphia, PA

Overview:

The City of Philadelphia partnered with SEPTA to create a Zero Fare program in 2023, which provides for at least 25,000 people between the ages of 18 and 64 with lower income. This program was built off of the SETPA Key Advantage program, which is a universal transit benefit program that participating companies can provide to their employees to receive commuter benefits such as acquiring SEPTA Key cards. Those who qualify for the Zero Fare program get key cards that look similar to the regular paid key cards.

The City of California shared about their pilot program known as the Clipper Bay Pass program, which provides unlimited rides on all buses and ferry in the Bay area, California. This pilot program started in 2022 and will run until 2027. They have two phases: phase 1 for university

students and affordable housing residents, and phase 2 for employees, transportation management associations, and property managers.

Lily touched on the digital innovations in payment methods, such as trying to move from one form of payment to having integrated systems. She spoke about three trends:

1. Digital identity, which takes into consideration people's online accounts and using one online account for mobility providers to verify "you are you." Using one account that is linked to an integrated system could also remove a barrier to access and can help identify people who may qualify for other programs, such as EV credit and affordable housing subsidies, amongst others.
2. Payments: to have a modern fare collection system where riders have more flexibility to choose how they pay for transit. There are locations where a different card is needed to ride transit and money is put into the card that they can't get back. The BankOn coalition was an option shared to help community members that don't have bank cards.
3. Mobility wallet pilot program that provides people with a preloaded card to use. This program helps users become more comfortable using a card, and eventually they get their own bank card and choose to use a card over cash.

The overall view is that more people will use public transit if it is accessible and free and the barriers to riding transit are removed. So when thinking about implementing a fare program, it is important to consider all options. A strategy should be created that includes all possible options that includes cashless payment. Also, there needs to be a conversation with stakeholders to understand the reason why people chose one form of payment over another. These programs mentioned in this session are currently in their pilot stages, and they mentioned that there is so much more that needs to be learned and justified of the value of each project, but it seems that these pilot programs have so far been successful in their respective communities.



Closing Plenary Lunch: 11:30 a.m. – 1:30 p.m.

Climate Action: Working Together for Equitable, Resilient Communities

Welcome: Carolyn Flowers, Partner, InfraStrategies / Vice President, Mpact Board of Directors

Mariia Zimmerman, Principal Deputy Assistant Secretary for Policy, Office of the Secretary, US Department of Transportation, Washington, DC

Laurie Schoeman, Senior Policy Advisor for Housing and Urban Policy, Domestic Policy Council, The White House, Washington, DC (Invited)

Ariella Maron, Executive Director, Delaware Valley Regional Planning Commission, Philadelphia, PA

Overview:

In this session, strategies to help reach climate and development goals were introduced that included embracing public transit, shaping cities, anchoring public transit, driving public transport to be just, and equipping transit for the future. However, like in the majority of the cases, having adequate funding is an obstacle.

In reference to funding projects, it was noted that we must think about the people the project is for and who it is serving. Mariia Zimmerman shared the quote, “Who is sacrificing what for who?” by Harold Baron. It is important that who is benefiting from the project and who is being affected by the project all have a voice in the discussion. Ariella Maron put into perspective that we cannot think about: housing without transportation; transportation without air; air without energy; and energy without climate change.

Additionally, while we need to move faster to make changes to address climate change, we have to move at the pace to include our communities’ voices. If we move too fast and are not taking the time to meet and talk with the community, the things done may not meet the needs of the community nor their wants. We are all in the middle of our story and need to do what we can now. While we can’t solve the entire climate issue, we can change what we do now to help make it better.

Furthermore, even if we know about a topic, there is always something more that can be learned, and this conference provides us that opportunity. It’s an opportunity to inspire and learn. The session concluded with the announcement that the next MPACT conference will be in Portland, Oregon, on October 26-29, 2025. The Metro Counselor, Juan Gonzales, addressed the group, sharing that they are the first state to ban single zoning statewide and welcomes everyone to transit in Oregon!



CONCLUSION:

The MPACT Transit + Community Conference offers attendees the opportunity to engage with experienced community leaders and professionals to learn and take back how we can make our community more equitable and sustainable. Even if you know about transit, there is always something new that can be learned. This conference is an opportunity to be inspired and stay informed of new and changing methods and strategies that can help make a positive impact on our community.

Lastly, I am grateful to have had the opportunity to assist the Hawaii delegation for the “Activating ETOD in HI and OA” working session. I was able to hear from other community leaders and advocates on their best practices and lessons learned to take back so that we can provide innovative ways to make transportation for Kalihi and island-wide more effective and equitable for all.

City Council
City and County of Honolulu

CLAIM FOR TRAVEL REIMBURSEMENT

Date: 11/1/2024

Traveler: Linda Marie Nunes

Event: MPACT Transit + Community Conference

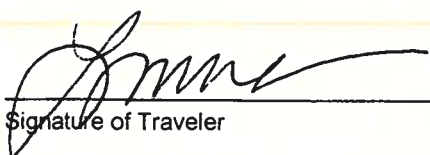
Location: Philadelphia, PA

Dates: From October 21, 2024

To October 23, 2024

Description	Amount	Notes:
1. Registration Fee		
2. Airfare		
3. Hotel	602.78	
4. Meals		
5. Ground Transportation		
6. Tips		
7. Other		
Other		
Other		
8. Adjustment		
TOTAL REIMBURSEMENT	602.78	

This is to certify that the above data, based upon receipts submitted to Council Administrative Support Services via a CCLTRVL02 form, is accurate. Further, I am claiming reimbursement for expenses associated with a trip in which City business was conducted and personal funds were used to advance payment:


Signature of Traveler

11/1/2024
Date